> been of the opinion that all political workers should be indifferent and should never bother about the legal fight in the law courts and should boldly bear the heaviest possible sentences inflicted upon them. They may defend themselves but always from purely political consideration and never from a personal point of view.[3]

It is clear from this that if Gandhi had a policy of ‘passive resistance’ to British colonial rule, then Bhagat Singh had a policy of ‘active resistance’. And yet while Gandhi is known the world over, Bhagat Singh is all but forgotten. In fact, Bhagat Singh went on to tell his father, ‘We have always been doing our duty quite disinterestedly.’ Later on he went onto reproach his father with the words,

> My life is not so precious, at least to me, as you probably think to be. It is not at all worth buying at the cost of my principles. There are other comrades of mine whose case is as serious as that of mine. We had adopted a common policy and we shall stand to the last . . .

Even in that last letter he left his father with no doubt that ‘I am still not at all in favour of offering any defence. Even if the court had accepted that petition submitted by some of my co-accused regarding my defence, I would not have defended myself’. Indeed, he then went on to reveal how the applications before the tribunal were all part of a wider strategy and a ruse in that ‘[m]y applications submitted to the Tribunal regarding my interview during the hunger strike, were misinterpreted and it was published in the press that I was going to offer defence, though in reality I was never willing to offer defence’.[4]

If Bhagat Singh was not going to put up a defence, what was he planning to do? Bhagat Singh has a clear answer to this. His approach was a highly sophisticated one. It was to expose the rank injustice of a judicial system of coercive colonial legalism. In this approach Bhagat Singh stood entirely vindicated because as he explained to his father,

> In the statement accompanying the text of the Lahore Conspiracy Case Ordinance, the Viceroy had stated that the accused in this case were trying to bring both the law and justice into contempt. The situation afforded to us an opportunity to show to the public whether we are trying to bring the law into contempt or whether others were doing so.[5]